

ECCLESIA DISCIPLESHIP & COMMISSIONING

**EDC 111: SPIRITUAL AUTHORITY, SUBMISSION, AND
ACCOUNTABILITY**

Introduction: Authority Is a Creation Principle, Not a Church Invention

Authority does not originate in the Church, nor in human systems of leadership; it is rooted in creation itself. Authority is the divinely delegated right and responsibility to represent God's order, serve others, and steward responsibility under divine accountability.

From the beginning, God established order, role, and responsibility. Humanity was given dominion as a delegated trust (Gen. 1:26–28) and placed within the garden to steward and keep it (Gen. 2:15). Thus, authority is not self-generated, but received: it is a function of divine ordering embedded within creation.

In Genesis, 'dominion' does not imply autonomous rule or exploitative control. Humanity exercises authority as God's image-bearer (Gen. 1:26–27), meaning that human authority is representative rather than independent. Adam was not the owner of creation, but its steward. This distinction is crucial: biblical authority operates under divine accountability.

After the Fall, authority became vulnerable to corruption through pride, fear, domination, and self-exaltation (Gen. 3:16–19). Consequently, Scripture not only teaches authority, but also reveals humanity's tendency to distort it. Redemption in Christ therefore restores authority to its original purpose: life-giving stewardship under God.

This reveals that authority is not a response to sin, but a means by which God sustains order and life. While certain structures of authority address the realities of a fallen world (Rom. 13:1–2), the principle itself precedes the fall and reflects the nature of God, who is not the author of confusion but of peace (1 Cor. 14:33).

Confusion arises when authority is interpreted through the categories of power, control, and domination. Jesus explicitly contrasts worldly expressions of authority - marked by coercion and hierarchy: with kingdom authority, which is expressed through service (Matt. 20:25–26). Scripture therefore presents authority not as ownership over people, but as stewardship under God, for Stewardship is the faithful management of what belongs ultimately to God. Leaders are charged to care for God's people without lording over them (1 Pet. 5:2–3), exercising authority for edification rather than destruction (2 Cor. 10:8).

A restored understanding of authority produces both humility and safety: humility in those who lead, as authority is recognized as a trust rather than a possession (Luke 22:26), and safety among those who are led, as authority functions for their care and formation (Heb. 13:17).

God as the Source and Pattern of All Authority

All authority originates in God and remains accountable to Him. Scripture declares that “*there is no power but of God: the powers that be are ordained of God*” (Rom. 13:1), indicating that authority is not self-derived but divinely ordered (*tassō*). God not only establishes authority but governs its rise and fall, for He “removeth kings, and setteth up kings” (Dan. 2:21).

For this reason, authority is never seized in its true sense: it is delegated. Even earthly rulers exercise only what has been “given... from above” (John 19:11). Consequently, no human authority is absolute, autonomous, or self-justifying; all remain accountable to the divine source from which authority proceeds.

Delegated authority differs from inherent authority. God alone possesses authority inherently and eternally within Himself. Human authority, however, is derivative: it exists only by divine permission and for divine purpose. Therefore, leaders are not the source of authority, but vessels entrusted with responsibility. Once authority becomes self-referential or self-exalting, it departs from its created design.

The nature of authority is therefore defined by **God’s own character**. His rule is relational, as that of a Father toward His children (Ps. 103:13); righteous, as His throne is founded upon justice (Ps. 97:2); and redemptive, as seen in the Good Shepherd who lays down His life for the sheep (John 10:11). God governs not to exploit, but to preserve and give life (John 10:10).

Accordingly, any expression of authority that contradicts the character of God departs from its intended legitimacy. While it may retain institutional form, it no longer reflects divine order. Scripture therefore establishes that obedience to God supersedes all human claims to authority (Acts 5:29), and pronounces judgment upon authority that enacts unrighteousness (Isa. 10:1).

Understanding this guards believers from both rebellion and blind submission.

Authority in the Life of Jesus Christ

Jesus Christ reveals the true nature of spiritual authority. Though He possesses all authority in heaven and on earth (Matt. 28:18), He does not exercise it through coercion or self-assertion. Rather, His authority is expressed through perfect submission to the Father. As He declares, “*The Son can do nothing of himself*” (John 5:19), not as a limitation of power, but as a refusal to act independently of divine will.

This pattern is consistent throughout His life: “*I came down from heaven, not to do mine own will, but the will of him that sent me*” (John 6:38). Thus, His authority is not autonomous, but relational: flowing from continual alignment with the Father.

Christ’s submission to the Father does not imply inferiority of essence, but functional alignment within the divine mission of redemption. The Son is eternally one with the Father in nature (John 10:30), yet in the incarnation He willingly took the form of a servant (Phil. 2:6–8). Thus, submission in Scripture must never be interpreted as lesser value, but as ordered participation within divine purpose.

Jesus taught with authority (Matt. 7:29) because He lived under authority. The New Testament commonly uses the term “*exousia*” for authority, referring not merely to power, but to legitimate delegated right. Christ’s authority was recognized not simply because of miraculous acts, but because His life perfectly reflected the will and character of the Father. His obedience was not incidental, but foundational. Having “*humbled himself, and became obedient unto death,*” He was therefore exalted (Phil. 2:8–9). His life demonstrates that authority in the Kingdom is not the product of self-assertion, but the fruit of submission.

In Him, there is no competing self-will “*I do always those things that please him*” (John 8:29) and therefore divine authority flows without obstruction. This overturns worldly assumptions: in the Kingdom of God, authority does not ascend through ambition, but descends through obedience. As Jesus teaches, “*he that is greatest... shall be your servant*” (Matt. 23:11), revealing that true authority is exercised through humility, service, and submission to God.

In the Kingdom of God, authority and servanthood are inseparable. Jesus washed the disciples’ feet (John 13:13–15), demonstrating that spiritual authority stoops before it stands above. Leadership in Scripture is therefore cruciform: shaped by sacrifice, humility, and service rather than status.

Authority Versus Control

A critical distinction must be made between authority and control. Scripture affirms authority as a divine trust, yet rejects its distortion into domination. Leaders are instructed to “*feed the flock of God... neither as being lords over God’s heritage*” (1 Pet. 5:2–3), indicating that authority is not expressed through coercion, but through care and responsibility.

Authority functions to serve God’s purpose in others, not to secure the position of the one exercising it. As Paul writes, authority is given “*for edification, and not for your destruction*” (2 Cor. 10:8). Control, by contrast, is marked by self-interest, manifesting through manipulation, pressure, and coercion.

Jesus explicitly contrasts these two paradigms, noting that worldly rulers “*exercise dominion,*” but declaring, “*it shall not be so among you*” (Matt. 20:25–26). In the Kingdom, authority is expressed through service, following the pattern of the Son of Man who came not to be served, but to serve and to give His life (Matt. 20:28).

Accordingly, where control governs, authority has departed from its divine nature.

Control often disguises itself in spiritual language. It may manifest through fear-based leadership, manipulation through guilt, suppression of questions, enforced dependency, isolation from outside counsel, or the treatment of disagreement as rebellion. Such practices may preserve institutional power, but they do not reflect the spirit of Christ.

Though position may remain, its legitimacy is compromised, for true spiritual authority guides, protects, and ultimately releases those under its care, reflecting the character of God rather than the impulses of the flesh.

Where control is present, spiritual authority has already been lost.

Submission as a Spiritual Discipline

Submission is not passivity nor the loss of identity; it is the voluntary alignment of the will under God's order. Biblically, submission is distinct from unquestioning compliance. Submission concerns posture and order, while obedience concerns action. Agreement may at times be absent even where submission is present. A believer may respectfully disagree, ask questions, or seek clarification while still maintaining a submitted spirit. Therefore, true submission is compatible with wisdom, discernment, and conscience before God.

Scripture presents submission as an active posture, not the absence of will. Even Christ, in His humanity, prayed, "*Not my will, but thine, be done*" (Luke 22:42), demonstrating that submission is the right ordering of desire, not its erasure.

This posture is consistently tied to spiritual maturity rather than weakness. Believers are exhorted to "*submit [themselves] therefore to God*" (James 4:7), indicating intentional yielding, while the example of Christ's obedience (Heb. 5:8) reveals submission as integral to spiritual formation.

The pattern of submission in Scripture is ordered: first to God, then mutually among believers: "*submitting yourselves one to another in the fear of God*" (Eph. 5:21) and within divinely appointed structures of care and oversight (Heb. 13:17). Such submission cultivates humility, deepens trust, and sharpens discernment, as the believer learns to distinguish between self-will and divine leading.

While discernment may at times require resisting human authority when it contradicts God (Acts 5:29), persistent refusal to submit often reveals not spiritual insight, but unresolved independence. Thus, submission remains a central discipline through which the believer is formed into the likeness of Christ. Submission is the voluntary alignment of oneself under God's order out of reverence for Him.

Submission Without Idolatry

Biblical submission is not absolute; it is ordered under the supremacy of God. The New Testament term for submission (*hypotassō*) denotes a voluntary alignment under authority, yet always within the framework of reverence toward God (Eph. 5:21). Because all authority is delegated (Rom. 13:1), it remains limited and accountable to the One from whom it derives.

For this reason, submission does not entail agreement with sin, silence in the presence of wrongdoing, or loyalty to error. Believers are commanded to reject and expose works of darkness (Eph. 5:11), and even apostolic authority is subject to correction when it departs from truth, as seen when Paul withstood Peter publicly (Gal. 2:11).

Submission, therefore, is rendered ultimately unto the Lord rather than to the personality or position of a leader. "*Whatsoever ye do, do it... as to the Lord, and not unto men*" (Col. 3:23). This preserves the distinction between rightful authority and

idolatry, for idolatry (*eidōlolatria*) arises wherever ultimate allegiance is transferred from God to a created figure (Exod. 20:3).

The apostles themselves modeled this order, declaring, “*We ought to obey God rather than men*” (Acts 5:29). Their refusal was not rebellion, but obedience to a higher authority. In this way, Scripture safeguards the believer from authoritarian distortions that elevate human leadership into the place of Christ, ensuring that all submission remains rightly oriented under God.

True submission increases allegiance to Christ, not dependency on people. Spiritual leadership is intended to point believers toward greater dependence upon Christ, not perpetual dependence upon human personalities. The New Testament presents Christ Himself as the Head of the Church (Col. 1:18). Therefore, any model of leadership that replaces personal communion with Christ through excessive human mediation departs from apostolic Christianity.

The Role of Accountability in Spiritual Health

Accountability, in biblical terms, is the condition of being answerable before God and within the community of faith for one’s life and conduct. Scripture affirms that “*every one of us shall give account of himself to God*” (Rom. 14:12), establishing accountability first as a vertical reality, from which all horizontal expressions derive.

In this sense, accountability functions as God’s protection against self-deception. Biblical accountability is restorative rather than intrusive. Its purpose is not the constant monitoring of private life for control, but the cultivation of holiness, integrity, and spiritual safety. Healthy accountability invites honesty voluntarily; unhealthy accountability seeks information primarily to maintain power.

The heart is “*deceitful above all things*” (Jer. 17:9), and therefore requires external correction and counsel. “*The way of a fool is right in his own eyes,*” but wisdom is found in receiving guidance (Prov. 12:15). Thus, even mature believers remain in need of oversight.

Biblical accountability provides correction without condemnation, as restoration is to be carried out “*in the spirit of meekness*” (Gal. 6:1); guidance without domination, as leaders are forbidden to “*lord over*” God’s people (1 Pet. 5:2–3); and structure without suffocation, as all things are to be done “*decently and in order*” (1 Cor. 14:40).

Moreover, accountability extends to leadership itself. Those who lead “*must give account*” (Heb. 13:17), are subject to stricter judgment (James 3:1), and remain open to correction within the body, as seen when Paul confronted Peter (Gal. 2:11). Authority in Scripture is therefore never autonomous; it is always exercised within a framework of answerability.

Where such accountability is absent, authority becomes vulnerable to distortion. The prophets rebuke shepherds who ruled “*with force and with cruelty*” (Ezek. 34:4), illustrating that authority without accountability inevitably degenerates into abuse.

Therefore, accountability is the state of being answerable before God and within covenant community for one's life, conduct, doctrine, and stewardship.

Mutual Accountability in the Body of Christ

While Scripture affirms leadership authority within the Church, it equally emphasizes mutual accountability among believers. The New Testament consistently presents the Christian life as shared responsibility, where each member participates in the spiritual formation of others. Believers are commanded to “*exhort one another daily*” (Heb. 3:13), to restore those overtaken in fault (Gal. 6:1), and to bear one another's burdens (Gal. 6:2), indicating that accountability is communal, not confined to leadership alone.

The Church is not merely an audience gathered around leadership, but a covenant community joined together in Christ. Each member contributes to the spiritual strengthening of the whole Body (1 Cor. 12:12–27). Accountability therefore flows not merely downward from leaders to members, but throughout the Body through relationships of truth, love, correction, encouragement, and service.

This mutual responsibility includes exhortation, correction, and restoration, all carried out in love. The community is instructed to “*consider one another*” toward love and good works (Heb. 10:24), and to teach and admonish one another (Col. 3:16). In this way, accountability becomes a shared function of the Body, preserving both truth and relationship.

Such a framework cultivates a culture where authority is balanced by transparency. Believers are exhorted to “*confess [their] faults one to another*” (James 5:16), creating an environment in which sin is addressed openly and growth is protected. As truth is spoken in love, the Body “grows up” into maturity (Eph. 4:15), demonstrating that formation thrives where openness and care coexist.

Conversely, isolation undermines this process. Scripture warns that one who separates himself resists wisdom (Prov. 18:1), and urges believers not to forsake gathering together (Heb. 10:25), precisely because accountability is sustained within community. Thus, mutual accountability is not merely supportive, it is essential, guarding against deception and enabling the ongoing formation of the believer in Christ.

Isolation is the enemy of accountability.

Spiritual Authority in Leadership Roles

Spiritual authority in leadership is a delegated trust, not a personal possession. Those entrusted with oversight carry greater responsibility, not greater privilege, for “*we shall receive the greater condemnation*” (James 3:1), and “*unto whomsoever much is given, of him shall be much required*” (Luke 12:48). Leadership, therefore, increases accountability before God rather than elevating personal status.

Scripture explicitly teaches that leaders will give account for those under their care. They “*watch for [souls], as they that must give account*” (Heb. 13:17), indicating that

authority is exercised under divine scrutiny. This establishes leadership not as autonomy, but as stewardship.

Accordingly, leadership authority exists to equip the saints, not to elevate the leader. Christ “gave” leaders to the Church “*for the perfecting of the saints*” (Eph. 4:11–12), revealing that the purpose of authority is to build others into maturity and participation. When this is rightly understood, leadership is governed by the fear of God rather than the pursuit of influence, as leaders are called to take heed both to themselves and to the flock entrusted to them (Acts 20:28).

Ultimately, authority is validated not by title, but by fruit. “Ye shall know them by their fruits” (Matt. 7:16), indicating that the authenticity of leadership is revealed in character, conduct, and the spiritual outcome in others. Thus, in Scripture, true authority is not asserted—it is evidenced.

Authority is validated by fruit, not titles. In Scripture, spiritual authority is inseparable from character. The pastoral qualifications outlined in 1 Timothy 3 and Titus 1 emphasize integrity, self-control, humility, faithfulness, and maturity before competence or charisma. Giftedness alone does not validate spiritual authority; character remains essential.

Abuse of Authority and Its Consequences

Scripture does not ignore the reality of abusive leadership; it confronts it directly. **Spiritual abuse is the misuse of spiritual position, language, or authority to manipulate, control, exploit, intimidate, or dominate others.** The prophets pronounce judgment upon shepherds who misuse their position, declaring, “*Woe be to the shepherds... that do feed themselves!*” (Ezek. 34:2), and rebuking those who “*destroy and scatter the sheep*” (Jer. 23:1). In such cases, authority is not absent, but corrupted: turned from stewardship into exploitation.

The abuse of authority carries profound consequences. When leaders rule “*with force and with cruelty*” (Ezek. 34:4), the flock is scattered and left vulnerable (v. 5), resulting in spiritual disorientation and loss. Because leaders are called to represent God, their failure distorts His image before those they serve.

Spiritual abuse often wounds a person’s perception of God Himself, especially when authority is used manipulatively in His name. Because of this, restoration frequently requires both pastoral care and the patient rebuilding of trust. Scripture reveals God not only as righteous Judge, but also as healer of the brokenhearted (Ps. 147:3).

Scripture, however, affirms God’s protective posture toward the wounded. He is the Shepherd who restores the soul (Ps. 23:3) and does not break the bruised reed (Matt. 12:20). Therefore, those who seek safety and restoration in the face of harm are not acting in rebellion, but in alignment with the character of God.

At the same time, God holds leaders accountable for the misuse of authority. “*Behold, I am against the shepherds*” (Ezek. 34:10), He declares, affirming that authority remains answerable to Him. Those who lead must give account (Heb. 13:17), and their actions are subject to divine judgment.

For this reason, any teaching on authority must include safeguards alongside instruction. Scripture calls believers to discernment: “*prove all things*” (1 Thess. 5:21) ensuring that **authority is exercised in accordance with God’s character** and not shielded from examination.

Teaching on authority must therefore include safeguards, not silence.

Authority, Freedom, and Maturity

Authority, when rightly exercised, does not suppress maturity but produces it. Scripture affirms that leadership is given “*for the perfecting of the saints*” (Eph. 4:12), indicating that authority exists to develop, not to control. Within this framework, submission trains discernment, as spiritual senses are “exercised” through obedience and practice (Heb. 5:14), while accountability cultivates integrity, sharpening the believer through relational engagement (Prov. 27:17). Authority thus establishes safe boundaries within which growth can occur, yielding “the peaceable fruit of righteousness” (Heb. 12:11).

As believers mature, there is a progressive internalization of divine governance. God’s law is written upon the heart (Jer. 31:33), and the believer becomes increasingly led by the Spirit (Rom. 8:14). External structures do not disappear, but their role shifts, as the believer develops the capacity to respond to God from within rather than relying solely on external direction.

Spiritual maturity does not eliminate the need for counsel or community, but it produces increasing inward discernment through communion with the Spirit and conformity to Scripture. Mature believers are not lawless or independent; rather, they become internally governed by truth, conviction, wisdom, and love.

The goal, therefore, is not perpetual dependence characterized by immaturity, but Spirit-formed maturity under God. As heirs grow beyond the stage of tutors (Gal. 4:1–2), they enter into the liberty of life in the Spirit (2 Cor. 3:17), where obedience flows not from compulsion, but from inward transformation. Thus, true freedom is not autonomy from God, but the ability to live in alignment with Him from a formed and renewed inner life.

Conclusion

Spiritual authority, submission, and accountability are not instruments of control but gifts of order. When rooted in God’s character and governed by love, they protect the Church from chaos and corruption.

This course forms disciples who are neither rebellious nor fearful, neither controlling nor passive, but **ordered, grounded, and governed by Christ**.

Signed:

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